

Q+A

# IN ON THE ACT

One of Indian fashion's brightest stars, **Masaba Gupta**, 33, is living her childhood dream of acting. This time, she has a part in the Amazon Prime anthology *Modern Love: Mumbai*

**Q. This is the first time you're playing a character that isn't semi-autobiographical. Considering you are not a trained actor, was that a challenge?**
I think that works to my advantage. It's nice to just go in fresh, with no experience, because then you're a little more relaxed. There's an interesting grounding exercise Puja Sarup, an actor and acting coach, taught me—it's a spine roll that helps ground you and block out all the external noise. I did this a lot while shooting for *Modern Love: Mumbai*.

**Q. Growing up, you wanted to act. Do you regret missing out on what could have been an acting career of 10+ years?**
Design was meant to happen. It helped me find acting on my own terms. Ten years ago, I wouldn't have got this chance. I am not acting to be a movie star. When your intent is to do something just for the love of it, I think everything else falls into place.

**Q. Creatively, what does acting offer that designing doesn't?**
I find acting to be a very meditative experience. You have no choice but to tap into the emotions you have known. You have to be centred, whereas designing at some level isn't 100 per cent for yourself. As an actor, I am reaching into my own jar of emotions, which never happens in other professions.

**Q. What have acting projects taught you about yourself?**
That I am not what people have made me out to be. Some friends think I am a highly emotional, wired, dramatic individual, but I think I have a lot of stillness in me. I only don't show that side to many people.

**—with Karishma Upadhyay**